

Tossing the illusion

While captains have overwhelmingly opted to chase in WPL, the data shows that toss trends, venue familiarity and results paint a more nuanced picture of where the **real advantage** lies.

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You could feel the surprise in the air when Gujarat Giants captain Ashleigh Gardner (**left**) opted to bat first after winning the toss against Mumbai Indians in the penultimate league-stage match of the WPL 2026 season.

The surprise stemmed from the fact that in choosing to set a total for her opponent, Gardner became the first captain to do so since Meg Lanning for Delhi Capitals against Royal Challengers Bengaluru in the final of the 2024 edition of the tournament. Neither captain that won the toss in the next three games opted to bat first, thus cementing Gardner's decision as an anomaly across the last two seasons of the WPL.

Across the 2025 and 2026 editions of the tournament, it is the only instance of a captain